

**Education****Harvard Government Department**
Ph.D. Government, *Karl Deutsch Fellow*Cambridge, MA
May 2028**Harvard Government Department**
A.M. GovernmentCambridge, MA
May 2025**Princeton University**
Emerging Scholars in Politics ProgramPrinceton, NJ
August 2021**The George Washington University**
M.A. Applied Economics, *Dean's Award*Washington, DC
May 2018**University of Michigan**
B.A. Economics & International StudiesAnn Arbor, MI
May 2015**Primary Fields**

Comparative politics, political economy, public economics

Secondary Fields

Economic development, cultural economics, narrative economics

References**Melani Cammett (Chair)**
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Papers****Protest Matters: The Effects of Protests on Economic Redistribution** (with Belinda Archibong, Evans Osabuohien and Tom Moerenhout). Reject and Resubmit, *Review of Economics and Statistics* [NBER working paper, 2026].

Abstract: Can citizen-led protests lead to meaningful economic redistribution? We study the effects of protests on fiscal redistribution using evidence from Nigeria. We digitized twenty-six years of public finance data from 1988 to 2016 to examine the effects of protests on intergovernmental transfers. We find that protests increase transfers to protesting regions, but only in areas that are politically aligned with disbursing governments. Two natural experiments- the large-scale 2012 Occupy Nigeria protests and 2015 presidential election- validate these results. Protesters also face increased police violence, particularly in non-aligned regions. The results show that protests can influence fiscal redistribution.

The Origins of Women's Economic and Political Participation in Africa. [Draft available upon request].

Abstract: Women's economic participation is not uniform across the world. Africa continues to stand out in its singular ability to engage women in the economy both in terms of levels of female labor force participation and heterogeneity. While the dominant explanation for women's (dis) empowerment elsewhere points to the historical introduction of the plough, Africa had nearly no exposure to plough technologies and instead was primarily characterized by hoe-farming. Still, African ethnic groups exhibited substantial historical variation in the extent to which women played a dominant role in agriculture. What, then, explains the origins of women's economic participation across Africa? I argue that whether contemporary African women participate in the labor force is in part driven by differences in historical norms developed from ethnic groups' gendered farming practices which were themselves driven by tasks necessary for cultivation. In the absence of plough machinery, societies considered reaping men's tasks and considered sowing and weeding women's tasks. This gendered division of tasks effectively gave rise to distinctly men's and women's crops across the continent. To test this, I link pre-colonial ethnic group data on whether women worked more (or only) in agriculture to gendered folklore motifs data, present-day female labor force participation data and data on political participation across the continent. I instrument for women's historical role in agriculture using exogenous grid cell-level crop suitability data and the historical crop classification of men's and women's crops established by social anthropologist Hermann Baumann. I find empirical evidence that women's historical economic participation in the economy, amongst societies more suitable for women's crops, predicts women's participation in the economy and household decision-making autonomy. The results also suggest that ethnic groups in areas more suitable for women's crops exhibit fewer gender motifs depicting female domesticity, female submission, and male violence in their historical folklore.

Works in Progress

What's in a Name? Toponyms, Origin Myths and Women's Economic Empowerment in Africa.

Do "female-named" communities reflect a social history that has led to more economic empowerment for women in some areas today?

Cultural Festivals and the Persistence of Gender Norms Concerning Women's Work: Evidence from an Encouragement Design in Nigeria.

Do cultural festivals, specifically annual harvest festivals celebrating "women's crops," generate the common knowledge necessary for progressive gender norms to be advocated for?

The Effects of Women-Led Protests on Gender Gaps in Political Participation (with Belinda

Archibong, Nonso Obikili and Oluseye Ajuwon).

Can protests lead to meaningful changes in political participation, particularly among marginalized groups like women?

Fellowships & Grants

Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, <i>Dissertation Writing Fellowship</i>	August 2026
Econometric Society Africa Summer School	July 2026
Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Mid-dissertation Grant	April 2026
Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Pre-dissertation Grant (x2)	April 2026
John C. Hansen & Katherine Vogelheim, Research Grant	January 2026
Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, GSA Grant (x2)	October 2026
Harvard Center for African Studies, Travel Grant	May 2025
Association for Comparative Economic Studies Summer School (<i>fully funded</i>)	July 2025
Harvard Government Department, Women and Politics Research Grant	April 2025
Harvard Jens Aubrey Westengard Scholarship	May 2024
Forbes 30 Under 30 N. America: Education - Founder, Research in Color Foundation	November 2022
Harvard Weatherhead Center for International Affairs, Summer Language Grant	April 2022
Harvard Graduate School of Arts and Sciences <i>Graduate Prize Fellowship</i>	August 2021
Harvard Department of Government <i>Karl Deutsch Fellowship</i>	August 2021
American Political Science Association <i>Diversity Fellowship</i>	December 2020
Best Overall Performance in the Applied Economics Master's Program, <i>Dean's Award</i>	May 2018

Teaching Experience

Harvard Department of Government	Cambridge, MA
Teaching Fellow for Matt Reichert	Spring 2026
Research Practice in Qualitative Methods	

